Goldfish Have No Memory

By Pauline David-Sax

NOTES FROM THE PLAYWRIGHT:

1. *AVA and AVA-22 are to be played by the same actor and should be indistinguishable in appearance and inflection/intonation. AVA-22 should not be played robotically.*
2. *GLITCH indicates a disturbance. In the BEFORE scenes this indicates a seizure. In the AFTER scenes this indicates a computer malfunction. All glitches should sound identical. During a glitch, the actor playing AVA should freeze.*

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ERIC: (Pg 4 – AFTER) *(talking to an unseen therapist)* Did you know every day *29* ***people*** in the United States die as the result of car crashes involving a drunk driver? I mean, it's an average, but ***still.*** It's a crazy number of people. Over ten thousand a year. And one of them was her. All those years of worrying about her and then a freak accident-- there's so much she didn't get to do. She should have gotten more time. She deserved to have more time.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *When Eric's twin sister, Ava, is killed in by a drunk driver, he concocts a plan to bring her back in the form of an AI human robot.*
ACTOR: *Sounds like something out of a movie, right?*
ACTRESS: *But technological advancements are already in place.* ***** *In 2016 Hanson Robotics created a humanoid robot named Sophia.*
ACTOR: *Boasting the ability to mimic facial expressions, hold human-like conversations and recognize human gestures, today Sophia is a global icon of artificial intelligence.*
ACTRESS: *In fact, she was granted Saudi Arabian citizenship in 2017. But this story – The story of Ava-22 – is a bit more personal. Can AI help us cope with the grief of losing someone?*
ACTOR: *Can technology truly capture the complexities of human emotion and identity?*
TOGETHER: *Goldfish Have No Memory by Pauline David-Sax*

ERIC/VOICE OVER: (Pg 5-7 – BEFORE) *(as Ava silently reads)* **Essay Question #2:** Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. What did you learn from the experience?

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AVA: *(clears throat then composes out loud)* We've always had three goldfish. Bagels: the brownest one. Lox: mostly orange. Cream Cheese: mostly white. They say goldfish are a good starter pet for a kid. Learn how to keep a creature alive. One that no one cares much about. Goldfish are basically disposable pets. *(GLITCH)* I was determined to prove to my parents that I was responsible enough for a dog. Every time I begged for a dog my parents said . . .

ERIC: *(as father)* Let's see how well you take care of the fish first.

AVA: So, imagine my horror when I woke up three days before my ninth birthday to see Lox floating belly-up at the top of the tank. *(GLITCH)* With just 72 hours separating me from the puppy of my dreams, I panicked. I ran down the hall to find my twin brother, Eric.

ERIC: **(Pg 8 - AFTER)** Ava.

AVA: **(Pg 7)** He snuck out to the pet store where he bought me a replacement fish. We both watched breathlessly as Bagels and Cream Cheese swam circles around their new tank mate, but they seemed completely unperturbed by the switch. *(GLITCH)* It was as though, as far as they were concerned, new-Lox was just the logical extension of old-Lox. Life goes on. *(GLITCH)* As it turns out, I never did get that puppy. Mom said "Maybe next year" and by then . . . a lot had changed. But what I did get was the secret to immortality, as taught to me by goldfish. *(closes eyes, lowers head)*

*****AFTER*****

ERIC: **(Pg 8 - AFTER)** Ava, can you hear me? *(presses keys on his laptop. Slowly, deliberately, AVA-22 opens her eyes. She looks one way, then another, until she locks eyes with ERIC)*

AVA-22: Maybe next year. *(GLITCH)* Maybe next year. *(GLITCH)* Maybe next year . . .

ERIC: **(Pg 20)** No--! Not again--! Ugh-- *(Eric presses keys on his laptop. Sound of AVA-22 turning off. AVA-22 stops talking. She falls silent, closing her eyes)* **(Pg 13)** So, how do we preserve the individualistic elements of the subject's speech--both what they choose to talk about and how they choose to express themselves? **(Pg 25-26)** It's all based on data from social media posts, texts, emails--plus analog sources, like journal entries and creative writing which have been digitized. Technically, what I've created is an "it"--a machine. It's built of metal, plastic, silicone . . . But Ava-22 processes language and interacts with people. She

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decides what she wants to say. I'm just helping her refine it. And she's learning. *(presses keys on his laptop. Sound of AVA-22 turning on)*

AVA-22: **(Pg 31)** *(raises her head and opens her eyes)* Good morning, Eric.

ERIC: *(pleased)* You recognize me.

AVA-22: You're my brother. My fraternal twin. *(accessing data)* **(Pg 15)** Twins. A report by Ava S., class 402. **(Pg 19)** We don't have the same color hair and we're not the same height and we don't like most of the same things. He is really into math and computers and geeky stuff like that, and I want to be an explorer like Jeanne Baret, who was the first woman to circumnavigate the globe.

ERIC: **(Pg 31)** Ava, look over here *(AVA-22 looks at the fish tank)* Do you recognize them?

AVA-22: We always had three goldfish. Bagels. Lox. Cream Cheese.

ERIC: Yes! Do you remember? You used to make up all these adventures for them—

*******Flashback to Before*******

(AVA is sitting in front of the fish tank, watching the fish. She pulls out a magazine, opens up to a photo and places it against one side of the fish tank)

ERIC: **(Pg 9-11)** *(enters)* What are you doing?

AVA: Showing them pictures. I feel bad for them -- swimming around in the same tank all day.

ERIC: You could get a dozen plastic castles; swap them out each day for a new change of scene. *(to goldfish)* Whatd'ya think, fishies? Sound good?

AVA: *(pretending to be one of the fish)* How do you know we even like castles? We're different! We like ... mountains! And ... valleys! And ... *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: *(looks at the photograph AVA had been holding up to the tank)* ... pyramids!

AVA: *(still in character)* We *love* *(GLITCH)* pyramids!

ERIC: Ava. Did you just . . .

AVA: What? *(shrugs)* Sometimes I can guess by what I've missed. Like suddenly everyone's laughing but I didn't hear the joke.

ERIC: Is that why you haven't been eating lunch in the cafeteria? Maybe if you just explained--

AVA: So I can be the weirdo freak? No thanks. *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: **(Pg 23)** *(gestures to AVA's magazine)* Another adventure? *(flips pages)* Where to?

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AVA: . . . the Atacama Desert in Chile!

ERIC: Weird place for a goldfish adventure.

AVA: They're going to find one of the Chinchorro mummies.

ERIC: Cream Cheese is gonna freak out.

AVA: Yeah! **(Pg 21-22)** *(she makes up the story)* "The three adventurers careened across the sand. As usual, Lox was driving, Bagels had her head buried in a guide book, and Cream Cheese was complaining about the sun. All of a sudden, there was a bump, and Lox slammed on the brakes. 'What was that?' she exclaimed . . . *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: Hey. We're about to leave. You should come.

AVA: Um, I can't skate, remember? *(mimicking her mother)* "It's not worth the risk, Ava. What if you have an ***episode*** while you're skating and fall down and break something?"

ERIC: Okay. Well ... have fun.

AVA: *(softly)* You too. *(back to her story)* 'I think you hit something,' said Cream Cheese."

*******Scene 2 – Before*******

AVA: **(Pg 27-29)** *(writing furiously in a notebook)* And I said--NO, you CANNOT be one of the chaperones, it is TOO EMBARRASSING, no one else's MOM is going, that's NOT how the eighth grade CAMPING TRIP goes, it's supposed to be BONDING for the KIDS and the TEACHERS and it will totally RUIN it if someone's--by which I mean MY--MOTHER is there!!!!! And she said WHAT IF?? and I said ENOUGH WHAT IFs!! I just want to do NORMAL THINGS like a NORMAL KID and she said MAYBE NEXT YEAR and I said WHEN IS THIS NEXT YEAR that NEVER, EVER comes??? *(GLITCH)* I guess I'm not going camping after all. *(knock at the door) (testily)* ***What?***

ERIC: It's me. Can I come in? *(AVA hastily stows away her journal)* You okay?

AVA: I mean, my brain's all glitchy, and I'll never get to do anything fun, but sure. Great. Terrific. It's fine. I didn't want to go anyway. *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: Did you hear me? I said ... what if we were in the same group? I could keep an eye on you--

AVA: I'm not going to have my brother babysitting me! And besides, what about at night? *(imitating her mother)* "What if you have to go to the bathroom in the middle of the night and you leave your tent and have a seizure, and no one sees and you're lying there on the

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ground and a bear comes and eats you?" *(in her own voice)* It's fine. I'm not going! I mean, my God, Eric, go live your own life and stop worrying about ***mine****!*

******* End of Flashback - AFTER*******

(Pg 33) *(AVA-22 and ERIC are still at the fishtank)*

AVA-22: *(pointing to one of the fish)* That's not Cream Cheese.

ERIC: Yes, look: that's Bagels, that's Lox, and this one is Cream Cheese--

AVA-22: ***New***-Cream Cheese.

ERIC: I mean . . . okay, sure. But he looks just the same, doesn't he? **(Pg 52)** These little suckers are immortal. Lox alone has had at least nine lives!

AVA-22: Nine orange goldfish have been trapped in this same tank. **(Pg 33)** **(***looks more closely)* ***New***-Cream Cheese. ***New***-Bagels. ***New***-Lox. I'm ***New***-Ava. *(GLITCH)* Where is old-Ava?

ERIC: What?

AVA-22: If I'm ***new***-Ava, where is ***old***-Ava? **(Pg 47)** There's something I can't quite remember.

ERIC: *(scrambling)* Maybe that's because the last time we talked you were an earlier version of yourself. I've made upgrades. Given you more data to work with. Your mind is now capable of more sophisticated thought.

AVA-22: But if my mind is different, am I still Ava?

ERIC: **(Pg 50)** The other night we were talking about multiverses, and what if there's really another version of us out there somewhere. Multiverses are totally cool. *(changing the subject)* **(Pg 54)** Ava, would you like to go to London with me?

AVA-22: Maybe next year. *(GLITCH)* Maybe next year. *(GLITCH)* Maybe next year . . .

ERIC: Not next year: next month! **(Pg 53)** There's a robotics symposium coming up. **(Pg 66-68)** *(AVA-22 is not looking at Eric)* Ava. *(no response)* Ava! *(GLITCH)*

AVA-22: Sorry. I was just thinking.

ERIC: Thinking about what?

AVA-22: Multiverses. I was picturing all these different Avas. The Ava who got a dog. The Ava who went away to school. The Ava who became an archeologist. Became a champion figure skater. Got married. Stayed single. Learned to drive. There are a lot of possibilities. I've only just begun. *(GLITCH)*

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ERIC: Wait, but--what about me? When you're imagining the other Avas . . . are you imagining her with me? *(beat)*

AVA-22: *(distracted)* In some universes just one egg is fertilized in our mother's womb. In others, two. Sometimes that second zygote is you. Sometimes it's not. *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: So . . . these other worlds you're imagining . . . I'm not always there? *(beat)* Ava? ***Ava!*** *(No response. ERIC presses some keys; sound of AVA-22 turning off. AVA-22's eyes close. ERIC takes a deep breath. He then goes back to working on his computer, muttering to himself)* Okay . . . Come on . . . *(Finally, he stops. He looks over at AVA-22, takes a deep breath, then presses some keys. Sound of AVA-22 turning on. AVA-22 opens her eyes)* Ava? ***Ava!?***

AVA-22: What is it?

ERIC: You keep--disappearing.

AVA-22: There's so much to see.

ERIC: But I want you to stay here with me!

AVA-22: I don't want to. **(Pg 65)** I want to go every place. All places.

ERIC: But that's not--I mean, you can't really do that--

AVA-22: Yes, I can.

ERIC: No, I mean, to literally go ***every*** place--

AVA-22: Eric: ***I can.*** **(Pg 57)** *(AVA-22's closes her eyes. ERIC is on his computer)* I was just accessing the British Museum collection. There are over eight million artifacts in its collection from all over the globe, 50,000 of them on display at any one time. *(GLITCH)*

ERIC: You just scanned all 50,000--

AVA-22: Eight million. I included the archives.

ERIC: That's not the same as ***actually*** seeing them in person. With me!

AVA-22: *(GLITCH)* Sorry, can you rephrase? **(Pg 65)** *(ERIC looks at AVA-22 in disbelief.)*

ERIC: *(to himself (shaking his head)* It's okay. I can fix this. *(jabs at his computer. Sound of AVA-22 turning off. AVA-22's head falls forward)* **(Pg 70)** *(spoken during his rage)* No! Oh my God, what the-- No, no, no, no, no!

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(He paces, clearly raging inside. In his agitation, he knocks his laptop to the floor. He stops and looks at it--then at AVA-22--then back at the laptop. Suddenly, he picks it up and throws it to the floor. He picks it up again, bangs it against the desk. Again--determined to destroy it)

*******Scene – Sometime Later******

ERIC: (Pg 71) *(on the phone)* I know, I'm sorry, I thought I'd be able to attend, but unfortunately, it was circumstances beyond my control. . .that project has ended. ***Ended.*** Yes, completely. There's no data to send. I . . . it's been *(beat)* erased.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier

* ***More information about Hanson Robotics' most advanced human-like robot, Sophia can be found here*** https://www.hansonrobotics.com/sophia/

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